

Speaking of Open Access

- Will speak quite informally
- Level of something like this is hard to pitch
 - Some of you will already know the ins-and outs
 - Some of you won't
- Will therefore start at the beginning
- I will address here the benefits of open access, but also the drawbacks in order to give a balanced view of the current situation
- Address popular misconceptions

What is Open Access

- Traditional model of research works, in the UK at least, like this:
 - University researchers are paid, usually out of taxpayers money, to do their work
 - They then approach a publisher, either university-based, or commercial
 - This publisher:
 - Gets the work peer reviewed
 - Carries out editorial functions
 - Typesetting
 - Proofreading etc.
 - Puts the work out either electronically or, mostly in the humanities these days, in hard copy
 - Once this is done, university libraries around the world have to decide whether to spend their increasingly limited budgets – which are provided again, in the UK, predominantly by taxpayers money – to buy this publication
- Now, can you count the number of times the taxpayer paid for the same research in that flow?
 - They paid once for the initial research
 - Then they paid again for every copy (probably hundreds) of the final version that was purchased by a state-funded institution
- There are also some non cost-related setbacks to this way of working:
 - Because the cost of production for the final product is high
 - This means that publishers are less likely to take risks on both:
 - early career researchers
 - and truly original thinking that is hard to recognize

This is where Open Access can help

- Open Access means that:
 - once the research has been done and been peer reviewed, it is put online in e-journal (or e-book) format with no cost to read

- Clearly, this cuts out the interim stage involving the publisher, but leaves unresolved the question of who pays for the services traditionally provided by the publisher
- The answer to this is, of course, that
 - peer review and editing must either be donated through an expectation of reciprocal treatment – and this is the preferred option
 - or they must be paid for by the institution or author who wants their work published

So, what's in it for an author?

- It's worth going over a bit of history of this type of mentality
 - I would strongly argue that much of the ethos of Open Access comes from the open source software world
 - Here, there is a movement of Copyleft enthusiasts who believe that software should be free, as in free speech, not as in free beer
 - In other words anybody is allowed access to the code behind a piece of software as long as they:
 - 1.) credit the original author (who retains copyright)
 - 2.) make any changes of their own available under the same terms (called strong copyleft)
 - They argue that, by producing software on a model of transparency and openness an environment will emerge that encourages firstly impact and reach
 - To a degree, this has worked
 - Phone handsets around the world running the Android operating system (which is open source) are currently outselling the iPhone at 17% to 14% according to Gartner
 - Similarly, Security Space's 2009 survey of web servers concluded that, likewise, there was a 75% market share to Linux
 - However, casual usage of open source software is somewhat more conservative.
 - Most people run Microsoft Windows (closed source proprietary software) on their machines
 - However, projects like Mozilla Firefox, which are Open Source, have achieved widespread deployment with end-users
 - The second area in which it is argued that this culture works is in terms of development:
 - If people can easily get access to your work, they can build upon it
 - This certainly works; the reach of the Ubuntu Linux project is huge and their dedicated userbase provide free support, fix bugs and continually improve the software

These areas all have analogies for researchers in the humanities who publish under Open Access

- It is only logical to conclude that, if people can get access to your article, more scholarship based upon it is likely
 - This has positive outcomes in a climate where bibliometric quantifiers are being used to judge the impact of research

- Greater access should lead (provided your work is good) to more citations
- In short, disseminating your work in a way that means anybody can read it increases the IMPACT of your work
 - – a term with which you should be concerned considering upcoming REF judgements
- There are two tracks of Open Access, green and gold.
 - Gold = publishing in a journal which allows Open Access to its articles
 - Green = publishing in a journal that doesn't allow open access and then self-archiving your work to an institutional repository
 - This is NOT self-publishing – it is self-archiving – it has been quality controlled
- Institutional repositories

Unresolved areas

- Copyright
 - What's to stop someone just copying your work?
 - You retain copyright on the work and, if citing it, people have the responsibility to credit you. Furthermore, different journals have different licensing policies.
 - It could be that you licence your work purely for reading; this would mean that nobody is allowed to copy/publish it except for the journal you have authorized
 - Conversely, Creative Commons licenses allow for people to redistribute under different terms, most of which will involve some form of attribution
- Acceptance and prestige

Categorical imperative

- Think to yourself: would you have it that, universally, knowledge should be freely available.
- Would you not want a state where, at the click of a mouse and for no further financial setback, you can get access to the scholarly outpourings that your taxes have already paid for?
- If so, you should ensure that you yourself publish under Open Access